The Mountainside

A Publication of the Coolfont Mountainside Association

Fall 2001 **Volume 4 Issue 4**

Board Reinforces Water Leak Policy

Over the past years there have been several cases in which members have received water bills for several times the amount of their normal usage. In most cases leaks were found and fixed. Sometimes meters were found defective. In at least one case, the meter was not defective and no leak could be found; the extraordinarily high meter reading could not be definitively explained.

The magnitude of the water loss problem is compounded for the association and some residents by the fact that most members are only part time residents and a leak might go undetected for weeks. Even a toilet or a faucet that drips for weeks can use a substantial amount of water. In addition, different levels of rental activity or usage by renters can distort normal usage levels.

The objectives of this policy - first adopted in 1996 - are two-fold:

1. to give some relief to individual members faced with extraordinarily high water bills;
2. to safeguard the interest of the association (that is, the members collectively) by -
   a. recovering for the association the actual cost of the water that has been lost;
   b. recognizing that there are substantial variations in water usage based on season and changes in house occupancy and avoiding the administrative costs of dealing with less than major variations;
   c. providing a significant financial incentive for homeowners to monitor their water use regularly, to track down any extraordinary usage and make necessary repairs.

With that in mind, the CMA water billing policy is as follows:

Members who receive quarterly water bills for more than double their normal usage, may apply to the CMA board for relief. "Normal usage" in each case will be defined as the average usage for the corresponding quarter for the preceding two years. In cases where such information is unavailable or where a house has changed from part-time to full-time occupancy or from non-rental to rental use, the Utilities Committee will make a determination based on the best information available and on the two objectives given above.

Such bills will be adjusted as follows: double the normal usage at the normal rates of $17 for water and $2 for sewer per thousand gallons, plus usage over this amount billed at the rate for the incremental cost of pumping and treatment. The Public Service Commission has established incremental costs rates for the CMA system at $1.34 for water and $1.00 for sewer per thousand gallons.

An example of how this policy would be applied: An average homeowner who typically uses about 15,000 gallons per quarter might have an undetected leak and receive a bill for 90,000 gallons or 6 times normal usage. At the normal rate of $17 per thousand gallons for water and $2 per thousand gallons for sewer, his bill would be for $1710 instead of his "normal" $285. Under the policy, the new bill would be for 30 times $19 plus 60 times $2.34, or $570 plus $140.40, or a total of $710.40.

A homeowner qualifying under this policy for relief of an extraordinarily high water bill must request such relief by letter to the Treasurer or the Utilities Committee within 90 days from receipt of the bill.

Adopted by the CMA Board, April 20, 1996 (updated for rates 5/16/00)

Board Meetings and Potluck Dinners

Nov 17th:
Board Mtg:
Bradfield (N-3)

Potluck:
Yingling (J-2)

Dec 15th
Board Mtg:
Barrett (K-4)

No Potluck
(Happy Holidays!)

Jan 19th
Board Mtg:
Joan Hash (F-4)

Potluck:
Farquher (Q-9)

Want to Know What's Happening Faster?

If you would like to receive notification of monthly board meeting, potlucks and other CMA information via e-mail, please send you address to Joan Bradfield, CMA Secretary at : jbradfield1 @juno.com.

ALSO:

Have you visited the Coolfont Mountainside Association website lately? NEW ADDRESS! Click on: www. geocities.com/ coolfontmoun tainside (Note: All ONE word, no underline)

CMA SOCIAL/ COMMUNICATIONS REPORT

by Joan Hash

The Social/Communications Committee was very active during the period successfully hosting a Newcomer's Brunch as well as carrying forward the potluck tradition. Members also assisted with the Annual Dinner under the leadership of Elmer Broxson. Special thanks for planning the Newcomer's Brunch go out to Nancy Thompson (Chair), Charlie Balkan, Flo Bender, Alice Minnamon and Gwynn Sirota. We also give "honorable mention" to Rosemary Bigelow for "emergency assistance".During the reporting period we also got help on hosting potlucks from The Borchers, the Auslanders, Flo Bender, Joan Hash and Martha Ashelman. Other CMA members, though not hosts, also pitched in to help.

The spirit of the mountainside is alive and well. At the September potluck attendees sang GOD BLESS AMERICA in recognition of struggle ahead as a result of the September 11th attacks.All in all, it was a very productive period for the committee and focus is now on continuing this success and working with the Recreation Committee to plan a SQUARE DANCE NIGHT IN THE BARN in conjunction with one of the potlucks in the spring. More to come !!! If members have other suggestions, please contact me.

Joan Hash, Chair

President's Corner – May 2001

by CMA President Richard Kaufman

Please Volunteer ... Or Else

It is, as usual, a beautiful Fall season on the mountainside. Here, all is well. If only things could be equally peaceful throughout the land. Those of us who have homes on the mountainside have much to be thankful for. In fact, in the past few weeks I have spoken to two persons who said they intended to buy properties on the mountainside as a direct consequence of the terrible events of September 11.

We had a successful annual meeting in July when we held elections and were able to announce modest reductions in the annual assessments and in the water rates. Our roads are in good condition, we have taken title to the common lands in the new T section - where a new home is already being built, and construction of the pool and office facility is under way. Our water system is working better than it ever has before. Our finances are in good shape.

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Recreation Committee Report

The Recreation Committee is currently focused on our swimming pool facilities. Our operations manager, John Hobday, has completed the initial plumbing work for the office/bathroom building. We plan on power-washing and sealing the pool in early spring and replacing the water filter, to reduce the chance of "dirty" water in the pool.

We will also be getting cost estimates for re-tiling the pool, and we will purchase additional pool furniture. If you can help with buying or transporting chairs, tables, chaise lounges, etc. (probably in the spring), please contact Marie Barrett by phone or e-mail (mrbarrett@mindspring.com).

Marie Barrett, Chair

PRESIDENT'S CORNER, Con't.:

There is also a strong sense of community among us. Those of us who live here only part of the year and who involve themselves in official and unofficial CMA events, such as the get-togethers following the monthly board meetings, know how rewarding it is to develop and renew friendships away from our other lives. One person was heard to say at a recent pot luck dinner, "I like to go to the board meetings because they're so funny." Well, some people will laugh at anything.

In any event, it is rewarding to see the healthy spirit of those who participate in mountainside activities. "Participate" is the key word in that sentence. What we need is more participation. We have a community of about 120 households, all of which are dependent upon water, sewer, road maintenance, control of land development, preservation of the natural surroundings, and security services. Yes, each member pays for these services. No, they do not come automatically from some outside source. The services are provided by those of us - your neighbors - who participate in the management of your affairs.

There is a tendency in organizations for a handful to volunteer to do most of the work. I suppose that is human nature. The danger of allowing that to happen here is that those who do the work in our growing community could become overwhelmed by the tasks at hand if others do not pitch in. There is an alternative to our kind of self-management. That is, to hire a management company to do it for us, and to pay the added costs that would follow. No one, I think, wants that to happen. So why not volunteer to help out – say, by joining one of our committees, or letting us know that you are available? No reasonable offer will be refused.

Richard Kaufman

Roads Committee Report

NEW ROAD NAMES

The emergency services departments who respond to 911 calls have asked CMA to name all roads on the mountainside that serve two or more driveways.

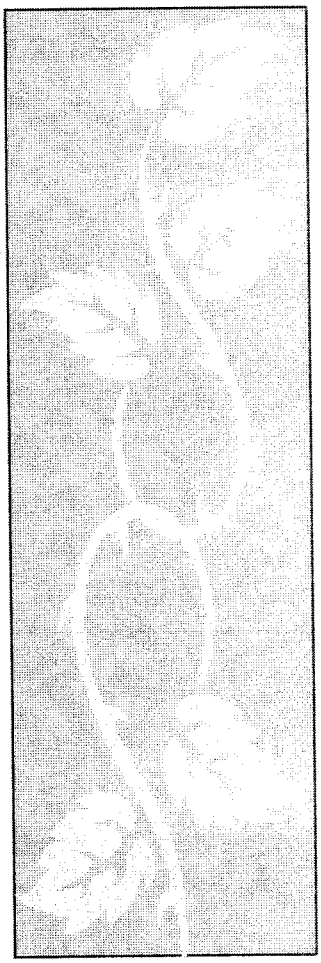
Emergency services informed us of eight such roads, and the CMA board has submitted names for them. The locations and the new names are as follows:

For the branch off Long View Dr.:
Warbler's Way
Serving K 13, 14, 15:
Magpie Place
Serving G 5, 6, 7:
Wolverine Lane
Serving F 4, 5:
Gopher Trail
Serving B 4, 5, 6:
Daffodil Terrace
Serving B 1, 2, 3:
Buckwheat Ct.
Serving A 3, 4, 5:
Rush-No-More Lane

Signs will be going up to identify the new roads, and emergency services will assign numbers to the houses on each road.

Lon Dring, Chair

Protecting Your House for the Winter



If you are new to the Mountainside, you may not be familiar with some important preparations you should make to insure your house stays in good shape during the cold winter months.

First, you must protect your pipes from freezing. A burst water pipe in your home could cause not only thousands of dollars in damage, but could empty our CMA reservoir, cutting off water supplies to ALL the homes!

When could those pipes freeze? Anytime you're away, and a power loss causes your heat to go off. This sometimes happens in Winter, when tree limbs snap and pull down power lines. John Hobday, our Operations Manager, recommends that if you are going to be away from your house for a week or more, TURN OFF the water at its entry point into the house (usually in the basement or near your water heater) and then empty the house water system by draining the pipes into the lowest sink or tub in the home. He also recommends protecting pipes that run close to outside walls with thermal wrapping. Your attention now could prevent a big problem over the Winter season.

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